

Whatever floats your boat: Kayaking offers unique outdoor experiences

By Jenny Wagner jwagner@timesonline.com | Posted: Saturday, May 12, 2012 10:00 pm

Powerboats have long been a familiar sight on the rivers of Beaver County.

Long docks lined with vessels of all shades and sizes jut out into the waterways up and down our river towns.

In recent boating seasons, slender, brightly colored kayaks have flooded the local seascape, and the Beaver County Rowing Association is aiming to make the increasingly popular water sport more accessible to area residents.

'TOTALLY DIFFERENT PERSPECTIVE'

Champion kayaker and BCRA member Diane Blackburn first got into a kayak four years ago.

"I've always appreciated water," the 48-year-old New Brighton resident said. "It's just relaxing to get out there on the water."

Blackburn, who volunteers as a kayak instructor for the BCRA, became a competitive kayaker and took first place in the women's sea kayaking division at the 2010 National Canoe and Kayak Championships in Peshtigo, Wis.

Kayaking has taken Blackburn all over the country and has allowed her to see things and go places she never imagined.

"The joy of it is you see an area from a totally different perspective," said Blackburn, who has paddled silently alongside cranes and geese and fish. "On the Beaver River there's wildlife and stuff that you wouldn't even know existed otherwise."

FAST-GROWING SPORT

Each year, more people throughout the area and across the country are discovering what kayaking has to offer.

Participation in the sport has nearly doubled in the United States -- from 3.5 million to 5.6 million people -- between 2001 and 2010, according to the most recent statistics from the National Sporting Goods Association.

Since it was formed in 2000, the BCRA has grown from a small group of rowing enthusiasts with a few shells to a club with a membership of about 25 and a fleet of 10 boats, which launch from the BCRA's boathouse on the Beaver River in Rochester.

Member and volunteer Raymond Tabay of Monaca said the group has seen a recent influx of new members who are interested in learning to kayak, and the group is hoping to soon be able to purchase more boats.

"People are seeing kayaks on cars or they're seeing a lot of kayakers on the Ohio and the Beaver rivers, and that's kind of what gets them interested," Tabay said.

Rob Walters, membership director for Venture Outdoors, which operates several kayak rental sites and guided events in and around the Pittsburgh area, said the water sources in the area also have caused the sport's awareness to grow steadily.

"The amount of opportunities with the water systems and the lakes in western Pennsylvania, as well as the state, are really endless," Walters said. "There are so many boat launches and so many things you can see and explore."

'ANYBODY CAN KAYAK'

The question Tabay said he gets asked the most by prospective paddlers is, "Can I do it?"

"Really, anybody can kayak," Tabay said. "There are waterways out there for every level of expertise and there are kayaks for every level of expertise and body type."

The local rivers offer ideal conditions for beginners to the sport, Tabay said.

"The Beaver River is good because it's really calm," said Tabay, who heads out on the water a few times a week. "There's no waking, so you don't have the huge boats going by, and there's long strips of water where it's not broken up by locks and dams."

While kayaking equipment has become more affordable, boats can set paddlers back from about \$300 for a basic river kayak to upwards of \$10,000 for racing and white-water kayaks, depending on material and design specifications.

BCRA members who have their own kayaks can store them in the boathouse, but Tabay said members with or without boats always have access to the club's equipment and instructors.

For those who want to get their toes wet before making an investment, the BCRA is hosting its annual Learn to Row and Paddle event from 9 a.m. to noon on June 2. Tabay said the event will include a water safety course, tours of the boathouse and guided paddles.

Tabay said those interested in kayaking also can call or email the club to set up a lesson and get paddling.

"No matter what shape you're in or your experience level you can get in a kayak and get out on the water," Tabay said.